Old and new narratives on the Common Agricultural Policy (CAP) in times of political turmoil

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Clingendael Report



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Executive Summary

The European Union is entering a decisive phase in the reform of its Common Agricultural Policy (CAP) for 2027-2034. This takes place amid geopolitical instability, climate pressures, and growing expectations and demands for more sustainable food systems and stable farm incomes. The European Commission has tabled reforms that substantially reconfigure both the budgetary architecture and direction of EU agricultural support.

This report a) analyses the unfolding debate and negotiations on the CAP; b) compares stakeholders and European Parliament groups positions on several proposed CAP interventions; and c) examines the possible implications of the proposals and possible changes to it, in particularly for the Netherlands.

Core themes in the CAP debate

The analyses shows that three general themes dominate discussions on the future CAP:

1. **Food security and strategic autonomy**, increasingly framed through a productionist and neo-mercantilist discourse, linked to geopolitical shocks, market volatility, and input dependencies.
2. **Competitiveness versus sustainability**, with diverging views on whether competitiveness is a prerequisite for, or in tension with, environmental ambitions; and the
3. **Targeting of support**, where broad consensus exists on the need for a better-targeting and fairer distribution of income support, but disagreements exist on how far to move away from area-based payments with mandatory conditions.

The Commission's narrative marks a return to a more productionist discourse (where income support to farmers is justified by their contribution to food production and security) compared to the Farm to Fork Strategy, which reflected a more multi-functionalist discourse (where income support to farmers is largely justified by or conditional on the their contribution to public good that are not rewarded by the market). The Commission's vision and policy proposals on the CAP still reference climate and biodiversity goals but prioritise food security, competitiveness, simplification and flexibility, and a shift from environmental obligations to incentives.

Key element of the Commission Proposal

The CAP proposal introduces several changes:

- A **restructured EU budget** integrating the CAP into a single National and Regional Partnership (NRP) Fund, with €293.7 billion ring-fenced for income support, but reduced overall agricultural funding and counting on increased national co-financing;
- **Redistributive area-based payments** that introduce degressive and capped support;
- A **new conditionality model** that replaces existing requirement with a more flexible framework, increasing national discretion;
- **Eco-schemes and agri-environmental measures combined** into a single agri-environmental and climate action framework, **without ring-fencing** environmental funding and an increased dependence on co-financing;
- Mandatory **Coupled Income Support** (CIS), expanding production-linked subsidies; and
- More **risk management tools** that emphasise insurance mechanisms and preventive resilience to hedge for extreme weather and drought.
- This is combined with continued investment in **innovation**.

Stakeholder and Political group positions

Stakeholder and European Parliament group positions diverge sharply (and familiar) on these proposed changes. Farmer organisations and centre-right political groups strongly defend area-based payments as the backbone of income support and food security, while favouring voluntary environmental measures over obligations. Environmental groups and centre-left and liberal groups argue for a reorientation towards targeted payments for public goods, stronger conditionality and systemic (and ex ante) approaches to resilience. Innovation is widely supported across actors but justified for different reasons: either to increase and reconcile productivity, sustainability and competitiveness, or to enable broader transitions in farming systems.

Implications for the Netherlands

The implications for the Netherlands are considered significant. The country faces a substantial reduction in ring-fenced EU agricultural funding (from €5.6 billion to €5.1 billion). Dutch policy priorities – strengthening long-term production, enhancing farm income, supporting innovation, and scaling agri-environmental measures – may be further constrained by budgetary pressures that follow from mandatory spending requirements in the CAP proposals for area-based and coupled income support.

While the CAP proposals provide increased discretion on how to implement these interventions, a complete removal of obligations to adopt coupled income support schemes or have a minimum spending on area-based payments, is seen as allowing for a greater budget for interventions that could help meeting environmental commitments.
At the same time, it is realised that this flexibility risks further undermining the "commonality" of the CAP across Member States. Under a more flexible CAP, diverging national choices could further fragment the policy and result in big differences in spending on different interventions, which is believed to undermine the level-playing field within the EU.
During both the negotiations and the implementation of the new CAP, balancing objectives of long-term production, farm support, innovation and sustainability, while ensuring a level of commonality across Member States, is seen as one of the main challenges for the Netherlands.

1 Introduction

On 19 July 2025, the European Commission presented its legislative proposals for a new Common Agricultural Policy (CAP) for the period 2027-2034. At the same moment, it also presented its proposals for a new Multiannual Financial Framework (MFF), the seven-year budget for the EU. The MFF proposals introduce a major restructuring of the architecture of the EU budget, amongst others by merging the CAP's two existing funds (or pillars), and integrating these with several other funds, including the Cohesion funds, into a single framework: the "National and Regional Partnership" (NRP) Fund.[1] The legislative proposals on the NRP Fund[2] set out several objectives relevant for the CAP:

- Supporting fairer and sufficient income for farmers and their long-term competitiveness, including the farmers' position in the value chain;
- Contributing to long-term food security;
- Enhancing rural attractiveness and living standards, ensuring fair work conditions, fostering generational renewal, improving farmers' preparedness to cope with crisis and risks, and promoting knowledge, innovation, and the digital and green transition in the agri-food sector; and
- Promoting resilient climate action, ecosystem services, efficient water management, biodiversity, soil and natural resources, and animal welfare.

The July proposals include a ringfenced budget for the agricultural sector. A minimal amount almost €300 billion of the NRP Fund should go to certain "income support" measures (see chapter 4 for more details). In a so-called non-paper of 9 November 2025, The European Commission suggested to revise its proposals. In response to strong pressure by the European Parliament, it suggested several amendments that would, amongst others, allow for an

1 The 2028-2034 MFF proposed by the Commission is based on three pillars: a European Competitiveness Fund, an instrument for external actions ("Global Europe") and the NRP fund.

2 European Commission 'Proposal for a Regulation of the European Parliament and of the Council establishing the conditions for the implementation of the Union support to the Common Fisheries Policy, to the European Ocean Pact and of the Union's maritime and aquaculture policy as part of the National and Regional Partnership Fund set out in Regulation (EU) [...] [NRP Fund] for the period from 2028 to 2034, COM/2025/559 final. 2025

additional ringfencing requirement for spendings on rural development.[3] In January 2026, the Commission suggested an additional amendment to its proposals, which would enable EU Member States to use funds reserved for unknown spending priorities for spending on agriculture and rural development (see Chapter 5).[4]
The July proposals on the CAP followed after the Commission's Communication on a Vision for Agriculture and Food was published in February 2025, which provides a broader overview of and vision for the EU agricultural sector (see below).[5] In turn, the Vision builds on various other strategic documents, including the Draghi, Letta and Niinistö reports on competitiveness and preparedness, as well as the outcome of the Strategic Dialogue established by Commission President Von der Leyen, following the farmer protests in Brussels in 2024.[6]

The Strategic Dialogue involved 29 representatives from various organisations, including farmers' organisations, the agricultural supply chain, financial institutions, NGOs, and scientists. In September 2024 it presented its findings and consensus, highlighting the need to strengthen farmers' position in the food value chain and modify the CAP. An important recommendation related to the CAP was to move away from current non-degressive area-based payments towards an income support approach that would be better targeted "at the active farmers who need it most". The Strategic Dialogue further recommended deploying a new approach "to deliver on sustainability" that would "properly reward and incentivise farmers providing (...) ecosystem services". The Strategic Dialogue also stressed the need to adopt a food-system approach including both

3 Gregorio Sorgi (9 November 2025) "Commission backtracks on its own budget proposal to avoid Parliament rebellion." Politico Pro. The ringfenced budget is 10% of the NRP budget, excluding the CAP and Common Fisheries Policy ringfenced amount for income support, the Social Climate Fund and the EU Facility. This target for rural areas is not defined but could include funding for rural development measures like the LEADER programme, support for knowledge sharing and innovation (AKIS), and territorial and local cooperation initiatives.

4 Alan Matthews 'Potential increase in CAP funding in next MFF', 7 January 2026. This suggestion was made by the Commission to appease concerns about the consequence of the Mercosur agreement. See also Farm Europe, 'President von der Leyen recognises that at least €400 billion are needed for the CAP', 7 January 2026.

5 European Commission (2025) Vision for Agriculture and Food

6 Mario Draghi 'The Future of European Competitiveness; Enrico Letta 'Much more than a market' 2024; Sauli Niinistö 'Safer Together: Strengthening Europe's Civilian and Military Preparedness and Readiness', 2024 ; Strategic Dialogue 'Strategic Dialogue on the Future of EU Agriculture' 2024.

supply and demand (i.e. diets and consumption) to promote a transition of the agri-food system.[7]

Not all analyses and recommendations from the Strategic Dialogue have been incorporated into the Commission's Vision. For instance, ideas on adopting a broad food system approach were hardly reflected or translated into the CAP proposals. However, several ideas continue to play a role in the debate on a future CAP. At the same time, geopolitical debates are intensifying in a time of great power competition, where the EU's agricultural and food sector are both subject of revised trade policies and considered as strategic assets.
The legislative proposals will be discussed and negotiated further by the European Parliament, Council and Commission and further shaped by stakeholders who continue to influence the CAP debate and compete to get their ideas and beliefs on the policy agenda in the coming months. To implement the proposals, an agreement should be concluded ideally before the end of 2026.[8]
While the Strategic Dialogue led to a somewhat isolated *policy* debate among policymakers and main stakeholders behind closed doors, *public* debate on the future direction of the CAP has somewhat resurfaced since the Commission published its Vision. Several stakeholders and political groups in the European Parliament (EP) have published their own ideas and positions on the future of EU agriculture and the CAP just before or shortly after the Commission presented its Vision. Many of them have also indicated, though often only in very general terms, which elements of the Commission's Vision they support or reject and why in different public statements.
These ideas and arguments by stakeholders and political groups will sharpen and continue to influence negotiations within and between the Commission, the European Parliament, and the Member States, particularly because most stakeholders feel they had little opportunities to engage in more detailed consultations with the Commission about its proposals. Many stakeholders complained about a lack of consultation on the proposals. Unlike in previous periods, no broad public consultation on the next CAP was organised, nor was an in-depth impact assessment carried out on different CAP options on which

7 Strategic Dialogue on the Future of EU Agriculture, 2024.
8 The MFF negotiations are planned to be concluded at the end of 2026. Normally, the CAP negotiations are concluded shortly after that. It is recognised by many that this is an ambitious planning.

stakeholders could provide input.[9] The policy formulation of the new NRP Fund has also largely taken place without the involvement of stakeholders. While several leaks[10] have been slowly revealing the plans of the Commission since October 2024, the outlines of the new Budget were formally presented in May 2025.[11] In chapter 4 we will describe in more detail the position of different stakeholders on these plans.

The limited involvement of stakeholders (both agricultural and other interests) also contributed to many ambiguities and uncertainties about how to interpret the different elements of the proposals, as well as about the rationale behind different provisions in the proposals. This, in turn, has raised concerns about the CAP's direction among a broad range of political actors and stakeholders along the political spectrum, with farmer organisations being most vocal in their critique on the proposal. The lack of transparency by the Commission also appears to have motivated the European Parliament's Agricultural Committee to present its own priorities for the new CAP on 7 July 2025[12] – a week before the Commission presented its proposals.

While it is clearly too early, at the time of writing, to indicate the direction and outcome of the debate and negotiations, a first analysis of the different ideas on the CAP (or specific elements of it) allows for an assessment of possible consequences of "different Common Agricultural Policies" for the agricultural and rural development policies in the Member States. These insights could be used to prepare for the implementation of the CAP or for developing a position on the proposals during the negotiations.

9 In the proposals the Commission refers to various activities that have taken place. This does not reflect a very systematic approach. More recently, the Commission has started publishing different studies on the CAP, including a scenario analysis, that have informed the proposals (see M'barek et al. 'Scenar 2030 - Pathways for the European agriculture and food sector beyond 2020' (summary report), 2025. We can only speculate about the reasons for limiting the participation of other stakeholders. One such speculation is that the Commission wanted to remain control over the proposals given some of the more radical reform that are proposed.

10 Gregorio Sorgi 'European Commission maps out 'power grab' over €1.2T money pot', 5 October 2024.

11 Bartosz Brzeziński and Gregorio Sorgi 'Farm fight erupts over Brussels budget shake-up', 1 April 2025.

12 European Parliament 'Agriculture Committee sets priorities for post-2027 CAP funding', press release, 7 July 2025.

With a specific focus on the Netherlands, the aim of this policy paper is therefore to:

1. analyse the different policy ideas and beliefs on several important themes in the current debate on the future of the CAP; to
2. provide an initial assessment of how these ideas could be incorporated into a new CAP; and to
3. evaluate the potential impact of these changes on agricultural and rural development policies in the Netherlands.

Outline

This report will address these objectives by first discussing different ideas and beliefs among different stakeholders and political groups related to the CAP. These ideas are discussed in Chapter 3, where they are compared with the vision on Agriculture of the European Commission. Subsequently, Chapter 4 will discuss several specific policy proposals put forward by the Commission in its proposals for the next CAP and compare these to the positions of different stakeholders and political groups. Chapter 5 will then evaluate the perceived potential impact of these policies and possible changes for the Netherlands.

2 Mapping discourses on EU agriculture: dominant values and problem definitions

2.1 Discursive analyses of the CAP

Ideas and beliefs on the EU agricultural sector and EU agricultural policy do not emerge out of the blue.[13] They are influenced by material, socio-economic and (geo-) political developments and contexts – in a study for the European Parliament, French research institutes Inrea and Iddri refer to four major developments relevant for the future CAP: COVID 19, War in Ukraine, Enlargement and the Farm protests that took place in Europe[14] – but also by ideas previously employed to make sense of these developments and contexts. Depending on these ideas, particular developments are considered salient or relevant by actors. These existing ideas have been referred to as discourses or paradigms, i.e. relatively stable systems of ideas i) about policy objectives ii) about (the meaning of) policy problems and iii) the (type of) instruments required to achieve them.[15]

In relation to the continuous reforms of, and policy debates on the CAP, three dominant discourses have been identified in the literature: a productionist, a market-based and a multi-functionalist discourse.[16] The main ideas within

13 Ilona Rac, et al. 'Agriculture and environment: friends or foes? Conceptualising agri-environmental discourses under the European Union's Common Agricultural Policy', Agriculture and Human Values 41.1, 2024.

14 Hervé Guyomard et al. 'Research for AGRI Committee: The next reform of the CAP: The variables in the equation. Volume I – Study', European Parliament, Policy Department of Directorate for Regional Development, Agriculture and Fisheries Policies, 2024.

15 Peter Hall, 1993, in Gerry Alons, 'The advantage of paradigmatic contestation in shaping and selling public policies', Journal of Public Policy 40.4, 2020.

16 Gerry Alons, 'The advantage of paradigmatic contestation in shaping and selling public policies', Journal of Public Policy 40.4, 2020; Isabella Garzon, 'Multifunctionality of Agriculture in the European Union: Is There Substance behind the Discourse's Smoke?', 2007; Mark Tilzey and Clive Potter 'Neo-Liberalism, Neo-Mercantilism and Multifunctionality - Contested Political Discourses in a European Post-Fordist Rural Transition', 2007.

these three discourses relate to the (de-) legitimising of public interventions (mainly through subsidies / income support to farmers) in the sector. Several counter-discourses and several more specific narratives and frames have also been identified (and labelled) by others – often in relation to specific aspects of the CAP. For instance, Rac et al. 2024[17] combine elements of existing CAP discourses with specific environmental discourses to analyse narratives on agri-environmental policies, whereas Buitenhuis et al. 2022[18] focus on the framing of resilience. However, the discursive elements of the three discourses remain dominant in the policy discourse, as demonstrated more recently in the work of Fiala et al. (2024)[19] on the discussions on the *Farm to Fork Strategy* of the Commission. In table 1 below the main discursive elements of these three discourses are summarised.

None of the three discourses have completely dominated the CAP.[20] In EU policy documents, elements of the discourses have been combined in different ways by the Commission. Also, several stakeholders have started to (strategically) combine and mix elements of different discourses in their narratives on EU agriculture and the CAP. As a result, associating different stakeholders with specific discourses has become more difficult.

17 Ilona Rac et al. 'Agriculture and environment: friends or foes? Conceptualising agri-environmental discourses under the European Union's Common Agricultural Policy', Agriculture and Human Values 41.1, 2024.

18 Yannick Buitenhuis et al. 'Reconstructing the framing of resilience in the European Union's Common Agricultural Policy post-2020 reform.' Sociologia Ruralis, 62(3), 2020.

19 Valentin Fiala et al. 'Diverging Stories on food system transitions. A qualitative analysis of policy narratives in the public consultation on the European Commission's Farm to Fork Strategy', Journal of Rural Studies, 110, 2024.

20 Karmen Erjavec, and Emil Erjavec 'The noble or sour wine: European Commission's competing discourses on the main CAP reforms', Sociologia Ruralis, 60(3), 2020.

Table 1 CAP discourses

Elements	Productionist	Market-based	Multi-functionalist
Policy objectives	Food security and stable income	Economic growth and wellbeing	Providing food and public goods like biodiversity and climate actions.
Problems to be addressed	Low productivity. Volatile markets and natural conditions	Low competitiveness Market-distortion	Low incomes. Market failures to reward public goods negative externalities. Environmental impact of (intensive) farming (partly caused by existing subsidies)
Policy instruments	Area-based or coupled income support.	Minimal standards to enable functioning market. Incentivising innovation across value chains.	Compensating for market failures and support for public goods.

In this report the different policy ideas and narratives found in the current debate on the CAP are discussed with the help of the three discourses, linking different discursive elements to actors' ideas about appropriate (and inappropriate) policy objectives of the CAP. Furthermore, an analysis is made of their understanding of different policy problems and broad directions for policy solutions. When appropriate, reference is made to other discourses or narratives that have been identified in the literature on EU agriculture, such as food sovereignty, "radical green" or an ecological modernisation discourse. Although these discourses are not considered mainstream, or reflected in policy documents so far, they are used by specific stakeholders.[21] The next chapter shows which (elements of) these discourses are employed by stakeholders and political actors in the CAP debate in relation to several general themes. In chapter 4 we zoom in on several specific policy instruments.

21 Ilona Rac, et al. 'Agriculture and environment: friends or foes? Conceptualising agri-environmental discourses under the European Union's Common Agricultural Policy', Agriculture and Human Values 41.1, 2024.

2.2 Methodology

For the analysis of ideas, the position papers of stakeholders that were most active in reacting to the Vision on Agriculture and Food and the CAP proposals, and who have been a member of the European Board on Agriculture and Food (EBAF) that was established after the Strategic Dialogue, were purposefully selected. For all EBAF members their response to the Vision and the CAP proposals were collected and analysed. The most active stakeholders were COPA-COGECA, CEJA, FoodDrinkEurope, Via Campesina and a group of environmental NGOs: EEB, Birdlife, Greenpeace and WWF. In addition, the position papers of five European Parliament (EP) groups were included (see table below).

Except for the position papers of FoodDrinkEurope and EP group Green/EFA, all position papers set out an elaborate vision on the EU's agricultural and food sector which includes the CAP. Most papers were between 15-25 pages. All position papers were published in 2025, except for the position paper of the largest group in the European Parliament, the EPP (Christian-Democrats), which was published in October 2023, and the paper of agricultural umbrella organisation COPA-COGEGA, which was published at the end of 2024. Besides focusing on the distributive instruments of the CAP, which will be central in the analysis below, most position papers also paid considerable attention to strengthening the position of farmers in the value chain via regulation and trade policies.

Table 2 Actors included in analysis [and their Dutch members]

Political groups	Stakeholders
European Peoples Party (EPP) [CDA; BBB; NSC]	COPA-COGEGA [LTO]
Socialist & Democrats (S&D) [PvdA]	European Council of Young Farmers (CEJA) [Nederlands Agrarisch Jongeren Kontakt (NAJK)]
Renew [VVD; D66]	Environmental NGOs Birdlife, EEB, Greenpeace, WWF [Vogelbescherming]
European Conservatives and Reformists (ECR) [SGP]	Via Campesina
Greens/EFA [GroenLinks]	FoodDrinkEurope [Federatie Nederlandse Levensmiddelen Industrie (FNLI)]

All position papers have been analysed and coded inductively, using *Atlas.ti* to apply codes that remained close to the wording used by stakeholders. This inductive approach let themes emerge organically from the stakeholders' own

language without imposing preconceived ideas or categories. This led to a general overview of key issues and themes being discussed. A second round of coding paid specific attention to the narrative structure in the position papers and focussed on how specific objectives, problems and solutions were linked to each other by stakeholders and EP groups.[22] Based on this analysis, "mind maps" were developed for each stakeholder and EP group, except for Greens/EFA and FoodDrinkEurope (being less elaborate for the CAP).

Initially, the aim was to look for overlaps in the different "mind maps" (and underlying data) of various stakeholders and EP groups to structure our analysis. For each combination of actors overlapping narratives were considered. This analysis showed that, except for some general narratives (e.g. "a strong budget is needed to address challenges") there was only limited overlap between the narrative structures of different stakeholders and the political groups in the EP. Using this overlap to describe the different ideas and themes being used in the CAP debate would not provide an adequate reflection of this debate. Given this divergence between the position of stakeholders and political groups three main themes were identified in the overall discourse on the CAP (see chapter 3): food security and strategic dependencies, the balance between competitiveness and sustainability, and the targeting of financial support to farmers. More specific ideas related to these themes were then explored and analysed with reference to existing discourses and narratives.

For the mapping of actors' positions on specific policy interventions (chapter 4) the same position papers were analysed and compared with the proposal by the Commission. This analysis basically presents actors' positions, but we also link these positions to the three discourses (see the tables).

The analysis of possible impacts of the new CAP proposal (chapter 5) is based in part on the initial appreciation of the Dutch government of the proposals, dating from September 2025, as well as several background interviews and discussions with several national stakeholders, their public statements about the CAP proposals and position- or background papers that have been shared with the researchers.[23]

22 While Atlis.ti allows for analysing the combination of topics / codes, we used a qualitative approach to analyse the topics they are causally linked by different stakeholders and EP groups.

23 The authors would like to thank these stakeholders for their time and sharing their ideas and insights. The overall analysis and interpretation of the data for this study have further greatly benefitted from the ongoing exchange on the CAP proposals with researchers of think tanks Agora Agriculture, IEEP, Iddri, Green Economy Institute (IZG) and Concito.

3 Main themes in the debate

This chapter reviews three main themes in the debate on the CAP that emerged from our analysis of documents by stakeholder and political groups in the European Parliament: food security and dependencies, the balancing of competitiveness and sustainability, and the targeting of the CAP's support schemes. Subsequently, a comparison is made with how these themes feature in the Commission vision and proposals on the CAP. This section thereby contributes to the first objective of this study.

3.1 Food security and dependencies

Traditionally, agriculture has been framed as a sector whose main task is to produce food, an idea that stood central in the aftermath of the second World War when fresh memories of hunger in founding EU Member States still existed and for which the CAP, amongst other problems, was considered a cure. This idea is most explicitly put forward within a productionist discourse. Adherents of this discourse emphasise the importance of food security for Europe, especially in the face of a growing global population. This discourse also includes neo-mercantilist ideas that stress the geo-political relevance of a strong domestic agricultural sector and the need to promote exports while reducing food imports.[24] Agriculture in this view contributes to broader national interests and goals.[25]

These ideas are clearly reflected in the current debate on the CAP and EU agricultural sector more broadly, most strongly in the narratives of the farmer organisations COPA-COGECA and CEJA and the EP groups EPP (European People Party) and ECR (European Conservatives and Reformist). In its position paper, COPA-COGECA (historically associated with this discourse) stresses

24 Mark Tilzey and Clive Potter 'Productivism versus post-productivism? Modes of agri-environmental governance in post-Fordist agricultural transitions', Sustainable Rural Systems.2005; Ilona Rac, et al. 'Agriculture and environment: friends or foes? Conceptualising agri-environmental discourses under the European Union's Common Agricultural Policy', Agriculture and Human Values 41.1, 2024. Note that the import of "inputs" like feed is not so much considered a problem.

25 Grace Skogstad 'Ideas, paradigms and institutions: agricultural exceptionalism in the European Union and the United States', Governance,11.4, 1998.

that "*the primary role of agriculture (…) continues to be that of ensuring food security.*"[26] Food security is also explicitly linked and extended to broader concerns and ideas about the "strategic autonomy" of the EU by COPA-COGECA. This linking is shared with EP group Renew, who stresses "*that EU agriculture should be recognised as part of Europe's strategic resilience, with potential synergies considered between agricultural and broader defence and security priorities*."
The coalition of different environmental NGOs, Birdlife, EEB, Greenpeace and WWF, also refers to food security in their position paper. However, they explicitly adopt a long-term and system perspective on food security, pointing not so much to the immediate risks of geo-political developments, but to the medium- and long-term risks of climate change and biodiversity loss for the continuation of agricultural production.[27]

Stakeholders and EP groups relate different challenges and risks to securing food security. A problem normally stressed in the productionist discourse is the idea that to (continue to) produce food and guarantee food security, farmers need to have a stable and viable income. Having a viable income is difficult, however, due to volatile markets and natural conditions farmers must work with, like the weather, as well as several other challenges.
Besides having a direct impact on individual farmers income, farmer organisations COPA-COGECA and CEJA point out to that these challenges jeopardise the attractiveness of the agricultural sector, which is a problem for food security in the long term, given the need for generational renewal. This is mentioned, not surprisingly, specifically by young farmer organisation CEJA, although they also refer to a range of other specific problems young farmers face when starting with farming.[28]

Volatile markets are often presented as one of the main challenges for farmers.[29] In the current debate we find much attention to volatile markets, especially for

26 EPP 'Position Paper on A European Farmers' Deal - The EPP vision for Agriculture in Europe', 2024, p.10

27 Birdlife et al. 'Time for farmers and nature to thrive; A proposal for a performance-based policy to drive the transition of Europe's food and farming sector', 2025.

28 CEJA 'A Common Agricultural Policy post-2027 for generational renewal' , Position paper, May 2025.

29 E.g. Grace Skogstad 'Ideas, paradigms and institutions: agricultural exceptionalism in the European Union and the United States', Governance,11.4, 1998.

agricultural inputs: in several narratives attention for the sector's dependence of inputs like fertilisers and feed is highlighted. COPA-COGECA[30] and ECR[31] stress the sector's dependence of fertilisers, which becomes a vulnerability for the sector (as a whole) due to high prices resulting from geo-political tensions. This became particularly visible following price shocks in the wake of the war in Ukraine, where energy to produce fertiliser skyrocketed in price and supply chains were disrupted by problems with scarce ingredients provided by Russia and Belarus. This was one of the reasons behind the farmers protests. EP group ECR stresses that import dependencies on fertilisers makes the agricultural sector less resilient (understood as the ability to continue to produce) to external shocks.[32] Environmental NGOs also point to the "*food systems' reliance on fossil fuels and fertiliser imports*" although they link the increased cost of these inputs to "*the vulnerability of many households to food and energy price hikes*".[33]
Dependencies of other imported inputs like feed (i.e. soy and cereals) is less problematized in the narratives of COPA-COGECA and ECR but is reflected in the position of other stakeholders and political groups. The EPP stresses the need to increase our European protein production,[34] both for food and feed, whereas EP group Socialists & Democrats (S&D) stresses the necessity "*to (...) decrease import dependencies on other [products] such as oilseeds and protein crops, and boost domestic food self-sufficiency*". Environmental NGOs also stress the "*vulnerability (of the livestock sector) due to heavy reliance on protein crop import*", although they also relate these imports to serious environmental problems like deforestation.[35]
Several other stakeholders and EP groups also refer to self-sufficiency in their narratives. EP group Renew states that "*the EU must reduce its dependence on imported inputs*".[36] Food processor organisation FoodDrinkEurope also

30 EPP 'Position Paper on A European Farmers' Deal - The EPP vision for Agriculture in Europe', 2024.
31 ECR 'Strong, Sovereign, Competitive; The ECR Vision For The Future Of European Agriculture', 2025.
32 ECR 'Strong, Sovereign, Competitive; The ECR Vision For The Future Of European Agriculture', 2025.
33 Birdlife et al. 'Time for farmers and nature to thrive; A proposal for a performance-based policy to drive the transition of Europe's food and farming sector', 2025, p.4.
34 EPP 'Position Paper on A European Farmers' Deal - The EPP vision for Agriculture in Europe', 2024.
35 S&D 'Position Paper on the post-2027 Common Agricultural Policy and the Future of Agriculture and Food', 2025, p. 22.
36 Renew 'The future of agriculture', position paper, 2025, p. 9.

emphasises the need to reduce dependencies on external resources. This will ensure Europe's food security and economic stability.[37]
In the position of EP group ECR we find reference to the concept of food sovereignty as an approach to food security, a concept also brought forward in the position of Via Campesina that originally introduced this term, meaning "*the right of countries and their populations to define their own agricultural and food systems and policies, without any dumping towards third countries*".[38] This plays an important role in the position of Via Campesina. In the position paper of ECR the concept is "re-appropriated" in line with a ("French") neo-mercantilist discourse and given the meaning of protecting farmers against imported products, while at the same time, "*promoting EU products globally*".[39]
Adopting a broad perspective, the EP group Greens/EFA point out that "*reducing our reliance on imported soy and other protein sources strengthens our own agricultural system, preventing deforestation and improving soil health. It also decreases our dependency on autocratic regimes [e.g. Russia, Belarus – authors] who profit from our imports*".[40]

Beside volatile markets, several stakeholders and EP groups also mention the challenging natural conditions that farmers must work in. Most stakeholders and EP groups pay attention to extreme weather events, such as droughts, floods and forest fires, being referred to as "natural disasters" by CEJA[41] and as "unpredictable climate events: by COPA-COGEGA.[42] In their position paper, Environmental NGOs also emphasise changing weather and climate conditions and their impact on farmers. This is already the case and will continue in the future. At the same time, however, they also highlight that "*science shows*

37 FoodDrinkEurope 'FoodDrinkEurope preliminary input to the EU Vision for Agriculture and Food', 2025.

38 European Coordination Via Campesina (2025) 'Post-2027 CAP: Building Food Sovereignty Fair prices, more farmers and a transition to social, sustainable and agroecological agri-food systems', 2025. p.2, footnote 4.

39 ECR 'Strong, Sovereign, Competitive; The ECR Vision For The Future Of European Agriculture', 2025, p. 3

40 Greens/EFA 'Six steps to sustainable farming', 2025.

41 CEJA 'A Common Agricultural Policy post-2027 for generational renewal' , Position paper, May 2025.

42 COPA-COGEGA 'COPA and COGECA Vision for the future of EU Agriculture' 18 December 2024.

that intensive agriculture is a major contributor to climate change".[43] In the contributions of other actors this link is not made or made less explicit.

3.2 Competitiveness and sustainability

The idea that EU agriculture should be more competitive is a second recurrent theme reflected in the position papers of several stakeholders, including COPA-COGECA, CEJA, and the ECR, EPP, Renew, and S&D political groups. To secure a stable and viable income (and thereby food security), farmers must be able to capitalise on market opportunities in Europe and beyond.[44] Most stakeholders frame the need for greater competitiveness (or the lack of sufficient competitiveness) through a more productionist discourse, in which productivity and (protective) interventions that create a level playing field, internationally[45] as well as within the EU, play an important role (see also Rac et al., 2024).[46] In its position paper, COPA-COGECA stresses that "*Europe must promote competitiveness and productivity*".[47] In a similar vein, CEJA stresses that "*competitiveness must be boosted by ambitious CAP intervention.*"[48]
In the context of the CAP, much attention is also given to the administrative burdens that farmers must deal with to meet environmental conditions that are attached to existing support. Several actors present these as conflicting with the sector's competitiveness, creating an 'unlevel' playing field compared to

43 Birdlife et al. 'Time for farmers and nature to thrive; A proposal for a performance-based policy to drive the transition of Europe's food and farming sector', 2025, p.2

44 In line with neo-mercantilist ideas, the focus on self-sufficiency and autonomy does not mean that exports must be limited.

45 In the different position papers we analysed, we also find several statements about trade policy. These statements are not directly connected to the CAP, however. In the current debate this link is increasingly made. See also footnote 4.

46 Competiveness is also associated with a market-based discourse. The main objective of agricultural production, in this view, is economic growth and prosperity (e.g. William Coleman 'From protected development to market liberalism: paradigm change in agriculture' Journal of European Public Policy 5.4, 1998). Food security, however, is believed to be also guaranteed best through a well-functioning free and competitive market (Marie Musch 'The EU's Position in the Trade-Food Security Nexus: Embedded Neoliberalism Reinforced" European Foreign Affairs Review 25.3 2020).

47 COPA-COGEGA 'COPA and COGECA Vision for the future of EU Agriculture' 18 December 2024., p. 4

48 CEJA 'A Common Agricultural Policy post-2027 for generational renewal' , Position paper, May 2025, p. 24

non-EU producers. While most stakeholders also recognise the need for stricter trade standards to create an international level playing field – which fall outsides the scope of the CAP – they also argue that strict environmental conditions and requirements (both within the CAP and other environmental standards) must be limited. COPA-COGECA stresses the need to simplify environmental and climate regulations for the sector as they undermine its competitiveness.[49]

In the current debate on the CAP, the environmental conditions attached to area-based payments are being challenged by several stakeholders who argue that farmers are not sufficiently compensated for these measures and that they introduce heavy regulatory burdens. This is said to undermine their productivity (and competitiveness). This dispute over insufficient compensation also reflects a broader debate about who should bear the costs of higher environmental standards, a debate that sits at the heart of concerns about both the level playing field and budgetary constraints.
In general, these stakeholders argue that environmental conditions should be balanced more effectively with productivity and competitiveness within the sector. Farmers should therefore either be rewarded more for the "public goods" they provide *or* be exempt from meeting specific conditions when they receive area-based payments. COPA-COGECA and ECR mostly invoke this counter-narrative,[50] although also EP groups Renew calls for the conditionalities attached to income support to be simplified, allowing more flexibility for Member States.[51] While recognising the need for simplification to a certain extent, Environmental NGOs and the S&D group in the EP, however, point out that this must not result in deregulation.[52] FoodDrinkEurope also stresses that "*the simplification process should never undermine the EU's long-term sustainability objectives*".[53]

Even if it is not perceived as being in conflict, competitiveness is at least considered to be a prerequisite for addressing sustainability challenges by

49 COPA-COGEGA 'COPA and COGECA Vision for the future of EU Agriculture' 18 December 2024.
50 COPA-COGEGA 'COPA and COGECA Vision for the future of EU Agriculture' 18 December 2024; ECR 'Strong, Sovereign, Competitive; The ECR Vision For The Future Of European Agriculture', 2025.
51 Renew 'The future of agriculture', position paper, 2025, p. 6
52 Birdlife et al. 'Time for farmers and nature to thrive; A proposal for a performance-based policy to drive the transition of Europe's food and farming sector', 2025 ; S&D 'Position Paper on the post-2027 Common Agricultural Policy and the Future of Agriculture and Food', 2025.
53 FoodDrinkEurope 'FoodDrinkEurope preliminary input to the EU Vision for Agriculture and Food', 2025, p. 8

several actors. COPA-COGECA, for example, stresses the importance of a competitive sector "*as we strive to respond to the societal demand for more environmental sustainability*".[54] The idea that a competitive sector (which will generate a stable and viable income for farmers) is a precondition to invest in sustainability measures is also reflected in the positions of ECR and CEJA.[55] In addition to a level playing field and increased productivity, entrepreneurship and innovation – i.e. developing alternative production processes or techniques, or diversifying products – are also seen as ways to boost the competitiveness of EU agriculture. Moreover, innovation is considered a means of maintaining competitiveness while addressing sustainability challenges such as climate change and biodiversity loss by several actors. Several stakeholders and EP groups therefore argue that financial support should be given to stimulate innovation. Renew and FoodDrinkEurope explicitly emphasise the need for the private sector to support innovation.[56] Rac et al. have linked this narrative to an "ecological modernisation" discourse that is based on the idea that competitiveness and sustainability can go hand in hand.[57]

3.3 Targeting support

The need for financial support and interventions to overcome various challenges is a related key theme in the ongoing debate and a prominent feature of the various position papers of different stakeholders and EP groups. Chapter 4 below focuses on the ideas of various stakeholders and EP groups on various specific intervention in more detail. This section discusses the various views on the distribution and targeting of financial support in more general terms.

Most actors consider income support through CAP subsidies to be necessary for the agricultural sector. In line with a productionist discourse, several actors

54 COPA-COGEGA 'COPA and COGECA Vision for the future of EU Agriculture' 18 December 2024, p. 4.

55 ECR 'Strong, Sovereign, Competitive; The ECR Vision For The Future Of European Agriculture', 2025.; CEJA 'A Common Agricultural Policy post-2027 for generational renewal' , Position paper, May 2025.

56 FoodDrinkEurope 'FoodDrinkEurope preliminary input to the EU Vision for Agriculture and Food', 2025; Renew 'The future of agriculture', position paper, 2025.

57 Ilona Rac et al. 'Agriculture and environment: friends or foes? Conceptualising agri-environmental discourses under the European Union's Common Agricultural Policy', Agriculture and Human Values 41.1, 2024.

emphasise the need for a dedicated and substantial CAP budget, particularly in view of the geo-political and -economic challenges facing farmers and societal expectations to invest in more sustainable production methods. This view is clearly reflected in the positions of COPA-COGEGA, ECR and EPP.[58]
However, in most of the position papers, there are also calls to move away from the existing area-based income support, which make up most of the CAP spending, towards a more targeted income support scheme for farmers who 'need' support most. Several stakeholders argue that this should include all active farmers, while other actors propose targeting specific groups or farmers (e.g. young farmers). Better targeting of existing area-based income support would lead to a fairer distribution of existing funds: now, 77% of the area-based income support goes to 20% of the CAP beneficiaries, according to the Commission. This change would also free up additional financing for other support schemes and interventions, which could be used to incentivise farmers to adopt more sustainable practices. Environmental NGOs emphasise the need for this change, claiming that existing area-based subsidies have worsened environmental problems by contributing to intensive and "harmful" agricultural practices.[59]
Rac et al. link this critique to a so-called "radical green" discourse.[60]
This "radical green" position differs with the view that emphasises the various functions performed by farmers, but which are not recognised by the market. As well as producing food, agriculture is considered to (also) provide public goods such as enhancing rural landscapes, maintaining sustainable rural communities and contributing to biodiversity and climate mitigation. This idea is found in a multi-functional discourse. A key argument within this discourse is that farmers are not sufficiently rewarded for these public goods, which thus justifying subsidies for the sector. This argument has been used by agricultural interests to justify the continuation of area-based income subsidies[61] and is reflected in documents from COPA-COGECA, the EPP and the ECR. In these documents

58 COPA-COGEGA 'COPA and COGECA Vision for the future of EU Agriculture' 18 December 2024; ECR 'Strong, Sovereign, Competitive; The ECR Vision For The Future Of European Agriculture', 2025; EPP 'Position Paper on A European Farmers' Deal - The EPP vision for Agriculture in Europe', 2024.

59 Birdlife et al. 'Time for farmers and nature to thrive; A proposal for a performance-based policy to drive the transition of Europe's food and farming sector', 2025.

60 Ilona Rac et al. 'Agriculture and environment: friends or foes? Conceptualising agri-environmental discourses under the European Union's Common Agricultural Policy', Agriculture and Human Values 41.1, 2024.

61 E.g. Isabella Garzon 'Multifunctionality of Agriculture in the European Union: Is There Substance behind the Discourse's Smoke?', 2007.

farmers are presented as the solution to address various environmental and climate-related issues.[62]

The "public money for public goods" argument was originally also employed by the Commission to maintain CAP subsidies but has become a basis to introduce several reforms to the area-based support scheme.[63] Recent CAP reforms have more clearly linked the actual delivery of public goods to area-based income support schemes, by introducing several conditionalities to this support. In addition, more ambitious subsidy schemes were developed, such as the eco-schemes and agri-environmental schemes that link payments to clearer and more ambitious "results" based on the adoption of certain practices.[64]

The conditionalities attached to the area-based payments have been the focus of recent debate, as mentioned above, with farmers arguing that they hinder production and competitiveness and should be relaxed. Others, however, stress the need to increase the ambition of the existing conditionalities attached to area-based payments. Beyond area-based income support, there is agreement among stakeholders on the need to reward farmers more effectively for adopting agri-environmental measures. According to most actors, incentives and a voluntary approach should play an important role here. Several actors also link this, however, to improving the performance and the results and impact of environmental measures.[65]

62 COPA-COGEGA 'COPA and COGECA Vision for the future of EU Agriculture' 18 December 2024; ECR 'Strong, Sovereign, Competitive; The ECR Vision For The Future Of European Agriculture', 2025.; CEJA 'A Common Agricultural Policy post-2027 for generational renewal' , Position paper, May 2025.

63 Isabella Garzon 'Multifunctionality of Agriculture in the European Union: Is There Substance behind the Discourse's Smoke?', 2007.

64 It can be argued that these interventions and payments are based on outputs rather than actual results or impacts. The link between both is an assumed one, based on program (or intervention) theories.

65 Birdlife et al. 'Time for farmers and nature to thrive; A proposal for a performance-based policy to drive the transition of Europe's food and farming sector', 2025.

Table 3 Positions on three main themes

	COPA/CEJA/ECR/EPP	Renew/Via Campesina	Envi NGO's
Food security	Linked to strategic autonomy		Long-term focus
Strategic dependencies	Reduce the dependency on fertilizers (also linked to income)	Attention for dependency of all inputs (including soy)	Stresses environmental impact of imported inputs
	ECR	**COPA/EPP/CEJA**	**Renew/FDE**	**Envi NGO's**
Competitiveness vs. sustainability	Competitiveness (Increased production) (first) => precondition for sustainability (second)		Innovation allows for overcoming tension Competitiveness and Sustainability	Sustainability first! No attention for competitiveness
	COPA/ECR/EPP			**CEJA/Envi NGO's/Via Campesina/Renew/S&D**
Targeting of support	Direct income support for all farmers without environmental conditions. Higher rewards/incentives for agri-environmental measures.			More targeted direct income support for farmers (for those in need), with (strict) envi-conditions. Higher reward for agri-environmental measures BUT based on clear performance and results.

3.4 The Commission's vision and proposals on the CAP

These three themes are also visible in the Commission's Vision on Agriculture and Food that presents a "*roadmap for an attractive, competitive, sustainable and fair agri-food system for current and future generations*", and the "considerations" that are part of proposals for a new CAP regulation.[66]

Food security and dependencies

Firstly, the Commission makes strong references to the strategic position of agriculture in terms of food security, safety and sovereignty, and the need for a secure and stable food supply. The Vision's conclusion also reiterates the need for a more assertive response to achieve strategic autonomy and food sovereignty. In his press release on the CAP proposals, Commissioner Hansen re-emphasised the importance of building a more independent Europe. This is linked to the need for a budget that can safeguard our food security. In the "considerations" of the CAP proposal this is clearly linked to geo-economic and geo-political developments, with references to "*uneven global playing fields, import dependencies, and vulnerability to geopolitical uncertainties*". It is stressed that this adds to the long-term uncertainty faced by EU farmers.

Additionally, the Vision emphasises the need for generational renewal and making the sector attractive to future generations. The Explanatory Memorandum of the CAP proposal recalls that "*the sector's attractiveness for young people needs a boost, as only a fraction of farmers are (sic) under 40*". According to the Vision, farmers must be able "*to earn a sufficient income to thrive*".

While the Vision makes clear that farmers need to gain a fairer position in the value chain to receive better revenues from the market, it maintains that financial

66 In its "Questions and answers on the CAP post-2027 proposal" the Commission itself provides the following answers to the question "How is the proposed CAP in line with the Vision for Agriculture and Food?":

- "The proposal reaffirms the importance of agriculture and food in the EU's budget and secures a budget for the CAP with ring-fenced resources to ensure European farmers can thrive and produce high-quality food.
- The proposal delivers on the Vision's goals by targeting income support to farmers in need, and introducing incentives for climate and environmental actions, rewarding farmers who work with nature and promote sustainable farming practices.
- The proposed CAP delivers on the Vision by simplifying rules, giving Member States more flexibility, and offering a wider range of support.
- This means farmers will get support that's better tailored to their needs and easier to access."

support through the CAP should remain part of their income. This is justified by the "*volatile nature of the profession and market imbalances*" in the agricultural sector. Building on this, the Explanatory Memorandum of the CAP proposal also stresses that the sector's many challenges make public support necessary. This reflects elements of a more productionist discourse, which is further exemplified by the statement that area-based payments should play a role here. At the same time the Vision states that these payments should mostly support those who need them. The Explanatory Memorandum to the CAP proposal itself clarifies that this includes "*farmers who actively contribute to food security, the economic vitality of farms, and environmental preservation*".

Sustainability and competitiveness

The Vision also clarifies that this "food security" approach must align with the EU's nature protection and decarbonisation objectives. The Explanatory Memorandum to the CAP proposal state that "*the sector is exposed to climate change and biodiversity loss, which threaten its long-term sustainability and livelihoods*". The Vision presents farmers in the first place as custodians and part of the solution here. The Vision emphasises that "*the opportunities from nature and climate protection can provide a positive agenda for European agriculture*". This reflects the use of a multi-functionalist discourse. At the same time, the sector is also identified as contributing to high environmental and climate pressures. The Vision, however, stresses that the entire value chain should play a role in addressing this issue.[67]

While farmers must contribute to achieving climate neutrality and combatting biodiversity loss, these sustainability goals should be balanced with economic and practical considerations: any sustainable measures adopted must be realistic for farmers. Strengthening the position of farmers is therefore important. To further overcome possible trade-offs between these objectives (and tensions between a productionist and multi-functionalist discourse), the Commission draws on a so-called ecological-modernisation discourse and presents targeted (local) solutions and innovation as a solution for this. The Vision notes that "*innovation opens new business models and rewards, making the transition to sustainability a win-win for farmers and nature while supporting competitiveness*".

67 Rac et al. 2024 found a comparable "careful" framing of the negative impacts of farming in the previous CAP Communication.

Better targeting, simplification and incentivising

Another solution presented by the Commission to support forward-looking agriculture and address the trade-off between production and sustainability is a shift in the CAP's focus "from conditions to incentives". The current system of conditionality should therefore be simplified to orient the future CAP away from conditions and towards incentives. Better-rewarded agri-environmental actions will encourage farmers to do more for the environment, climate, biodiversity and animal welfare on a voluntary basis. To farm in a nature-friendly way, "*better targeted public support from the future CAP*" is required, according to the Commission.

As usual, the Commission integrates and combines elements of a productionist and multi-functionalist discourse in its Vision on European agriculture and the CAP. Whereas the Farm to Fork Strategy stressed the need to move European agriculture in a more sustainable direction and moved away from a productionist discourse[68], the current Vision brings this discourse back to the centre of the debate by linking concerns about food security and production to uncertain geo-political and -economic developments. The shift in focus "from conditions to incentives" in relation to environmental and climate actions can still be interpreted in terms of a multi-functionalist discourse, although it strongly reflects the right of farmers to be paid for service that the market does not reward.[69]

68 Nora Förell et al. 'From Sustainability to Competitiveness: what shifting narratives means for EU agricultural policy, IEEP, 2025.

69 See also Gerry Alons and Pieter Zwaan 'New wine in different bottles: negotiating and selling the CAP post-2013 reform' Sociologia Ruralis 56.3, 2016. This interpretation was found in Germany in relation to the greening of area-based payments of the CAP in 2013. In the UK, by contrast, the interpretation that taxpayers should get value for money was more dominant.

4 Linking values and problems to solutions: policy interventions and support

Below we will describe in more detail how these ideas have been translated into policy instruments and interventions (although an explicit link between both is not always reflected) within the Commission's new CAP proposals and discuss and reflect on how these align with the positions of different stakeholders and EP groups, as specified in their position papers. To keep the text concise, we do not refer to the position papers of different stakeholders and parliamentary groups with footnotes. A list of references to the position papers of the different stakeholders and EP groups is found in Annex I.

Member States will have some flexibility in allocating CAP funding to different interventions. However, several provisions in the proposals will structure their choices by including obligations to adopt certain interventions or by setting minimum and maximum spending levels, as will become clear below. The allocation of the funding to different intervention, moreover, is affected by several more "horizontal requirements". Article 4 of the CAP regulation proposal, for example, sets out the requirement to provide support on six specific environmental and climate priority areas through several interventions. In the proposal for the Performance Framework Regulation of the MFF it is further stated that at least 43% of the overall financial budget for the NRP Plans (which includes the plans for implementing the CAP) are expected to contribute to climate and environmental objectives (this also referred to as climate and environment tracking).[70] As has been the case with the current CAP, the Commission will provide recommendations to the Member States before they start drafting their plans and will have to approve them. To what extent this will provide sufficient possibilities to check if these horizontal requirements are sufficiently addressed must be seen.

70 European Commission, 'Proposal for a Regulation of the European Parliament and of the Council establishing a budget expenditure tracking and performance framework and other horizontal rules for the Union programmes and activities. COM (2025) 545 final', 16 July 2025.

4.1 The budget

The post-2027 CAP and MFF proposal introduce a major restructuring of the EU's financial architecture by merging the CAP's two pillars into a single framework under the new "National and Regional Partnership" (NRP) Fund for economic, social and territorial cohesion, agriculture and rural development, fisheries and security. Of the €782.9 billion set aside for NRP Plans, €293.7 billion is ringfenced for CAP income support to guarantee a minimum level of agricultural spending.[71] This includes area-based income support, coupled support, payments for natural and other area specific constraints; support for disadvantages resulting from mandatory requirements and agri-environmental and climate actions. Next to the ringfenced budget, there is an unringfenced budget for the NRP plans that Member States can turn to. The €293.7 billion represents a decrease from the current €387.8 billion CAP budget, but it only covers what is now called "income support" and therefore does not represent the total agricultural budget if additional financing from the unringfenced budget and national co-financing is included.[72]

Area-based income support, crop-specific payments for cotton, coupled support and small-farmer schemes remain fully (i.e. 100%) EU-funded. However, all other "income support" interventions within the ringfenced budget will now require national co-financing of 30%. For the unringfenced budget a co-financing rate of up to 60% will be required, depending on a region's level of development. For the Netherlands, 60% cofinancing will be required in most regions to make use of the unringfenced budget, which will also apply to alternative uses for these funds.

71 Ministerie van LVVN, 'Fiche 5: Voorstel nieuw gemeenschappelijk landbouwbeleid na 2027', September 2025.

72 Alan Matthews 'The Commission's CAP budget proposal in the next MFF', July 19, 2025.

Table 4 Overview of co-financing requirements per intervention

Intervention	Ringfenced budget	Unringfenced budget
Income support interventions • Area-based income support • Coupled support • Crop specific payments for cotton • Payments for small farmers	100% EU funding	Not applicable
• Payments for natural and other area specific constraints • Support for disadvantages resulting from mandatory requirements • Agri-environmental and climate actions • Support for risk management tools • Support for investments for farmers and forest holders • Support for setting-up of young farmers, new farmers, rural business and startups and development of small farms • Support for farm relief services.	30% co-financing	30-60% co-financing
Non-income support interventions • LEADER • Support for knowledge sharing and innovation in agriculture, forestry and rural areas • Territorial and local cooperation initiatives • Interventions in outermost region • Interventions in smaller Aegean islands • EU school scheme referred to in Title I, Part II, Chapter IIa, of Regulation (EU) No 1308/2013 of the European Parliament and of the Council; • Interventions in certain sectors referred to in Title I, Part II, Chapter IIa, of Regulation (EU) No 1308/2013 • Crisis payments for farmers	Not applicable	15-60% co-financing

The intention behind the integration of the funds is that Member States will have more flexibility to distribute funds across interventions. However, Matthews[73] notes that because of this, actual agricultural spending for the post-2027 CAP will depend strongly on Member States' NRP Plans and priorities. Hart and Baldock (2025), and Régnier et al. (2025) warn that the CAP will now compete for funds with non-agricultural policy priorities within the NRP Plans, affecting the agricultural budget.[74]

The Commission, however, has argued that the funds do not necessarily compete with one another. In fact, it argues that agriculture can benefit from synergies within the broader NRP Fund, as the sector can draw on broader EU investments

73 Alan Matthews 'How big will the CAP budget be in the next MFF?', September 4, 2025.

74 Kaley Hart and David Baldock 'The post-2027 CAP and MFF proposals for the EU: first reflections on their environmental implications', IEEP, 2025; Elsa Régnier et al. 'European Financial Framework 2028-2034: Key issues for the agricultural sector', Iddri, 2025.

that also address the needs of farmers (e.g. in areas such as energy, climate, digital, infrastructure, social, skills and care measures).[75]

Position by stakeholders and European Parliament groups

The positions taken by stakeholders and European Parliament groups reveal broad resistance to merging the CAP funds into a single framework. Across the political spectrum, EP groups emphasized (even before the proposals were presented) that the CAP must remain a distinct, common policy with a strong and dedicated budget. ECR, for example, warned that integrating agriculture into a Single (NRP) Fund would risk diluting agricultural support and threaten farmers' livelihoods. S&D adds that renationalising the budget must be avoided to maintain the CAP's commonality; a concern commonly linked to maintaining a level playing field across Member States. On top of insisting on a strong CAP budget, S&D, like Renew, highlights the need for it to be inflation adjusted. COPA-COGECA, Via Campesina and CEJA echo the view of the parliamentary groups, linking the need for a strong budget not only for area-based payments, but also for addressing broader challenges (such as sustainability and climate change), and for maintaining a level playing field. Overall, this reflects a more productionist and multi-functionalist position in which a strong budget is considered necessary to intervene in the sector. In contrast, Environmental NGOs focus on the composition of the spending rather than its structure, demanding a ringfenced funding for environmental and climate objectives, something which is the case under the current CAP, but no longer guaranteed in the new proposal.

Table 5 Actor positions on budgetary reforms

Position	Explanation	Actors	Discourse
Maintain a distinct CAP structure with a strong budget	Opposes merging CAP into a Single Fund. Insists on a dedicated, common, and strengthened CAP budget.	COPA-COGEGA, Via Campesina, CEJA Renew, S&D, EPP, ECR	Productionist, Multi-functionalist
Ringfenced funding for environmental objectives	Focus on CAP composition rather than structure; demands guaranteed funding for climate, environmental and climate objectives.	Environmental NGOs	Multi-functionalist

75 European Commission 'Factsheet Europe's budget; Unlocking synergies integrating EU funding for farming and rural communities' January 2026. The

4.2 Area-based payments and conditionalities

Introducing degressivity and capping for more targeted payments

A central feature of the post-2027 CAP proposal is the reform of area-based income support, which becomes both degressive and capped. Currently, payments are calculated based on hectares farmed and payment rates are differentiated across Member States.[76] The new system introduces a more "*socially targeted*" approach, differentiating payments by groups of farmers and regions to prioritize young, new, small, family and female farmers, as well as those combining crop and livestock production or farmers operating in areas with natural constraints.

Degressivity entails that area-based payments above €20,000 per year will be gradually reduced, with payments being capped at €100,000 per year. By 2032, farmers receiving retirement entitlements will also no longer be eligible for area-based payments, ensuring that CAP income support goes to active farmers contributing to food security. In the proposals, there is also a requirement for a minimum national average spending of €130 per hectare and a maximum spending €240 per hectare, implying a more specific ringfencing for area-based support.

This proposal reflects the position in the Vision to *support those who need them*. The new system aims to improve fairness and income distribution both within and between Member States. It could thereby also free financial resources within the CAP budget (considering that area-based income support is its largest expense) for other interventions of the CAP.[77] In the long term, the proposed changes would also make it more easy to enlarge the EU with new Member States,[78] although this argument is not publicly invoked by the Commission, as an enlargement is not foreseen during the new MFF period.

76 Elsa Régnier, et al. 'European Financial Framework 2028-2034: Key issues for the agricultural sector'. Iddri, 2025.

77 Elsa Régnier, et al. 'European Financial Framework 2028-2034: Key issues for the agricultural sector', Iddri, 2025.

78 Elsa Régnier and Aurelie Catallo 'The Ukrainian agricultural sector: an overview and challenges in light of possible European Union enlargement', Iddri 2024.

So far, it is not clear how this differentiation across target groups will work in practice, as Member States will have considerable room for manoeuvring in designing this support.[79]

Position by stakeholders and European Parliament groups

The Commission's proposals on area-based income support reflects a position shared among most interest groups and EP groups on the need for a fairer system of income distribution. The views of actors, however, diverge on how far to move away from the existing area-based model.

Among stakeholders, COPA-COGECA maintains that direct support should remain accessible to all active farmers, regardless of their size of production type. By contrast, CEJA and VIA CAMPESINA argue that stronger targeting is required, including capping and degressivity. Environmental NGOs go further, favouring a complete shift away from the area-based system. They propose a system that is more targeted towards environmental objectives.

Among EP groups, Renew also supports the proposed measures, but adds that they should be adapted to reflect Member States' socio-economic conditions and incorporate results-oriented elements. S&D views degressivity and capping as a transitional tool towards a fairer system of income redistribution, generally understood in their position as a redirection of support towards smaller and low-income farms. They do not outline a clear framework for this. EPP and ECR, though less specific in their positions, underscore the importance of maintaining areas-based support. ECR calls for more tailored support but reject targeting based on non-agricultural objectives.

Across positions, most actors thus call for limiting payments to active farmers, in line with the CAP proposal's revised definition. In sum, a consensus is growing around the need for more targeted income support, yet the degree to which this should remain area-based and include social over other criteria remains contested.

Farm Stewardship: the new conditionality

Closely related to the discussion on area-based payments are its conditions. Under the existing system, farmers that apply for area-based support must comply with several requirements. Non-compliance by farmers will have

79 In the European Commission's recent Communication on Generational Renewal in Agriculture (October 2025), it indicates that it will recommend Member States to allocate at least 6% of the ringfenced income support to young farmers. Part of this could be "delivered" by diversified area-based payments.

consequences for this support.[80] The Commission's post-2027 proposal introduces Farm Stewardship to replace the current conditionality system. Introducing Farm Stewardship continues the simplification trend started in 2023 in response to the farmer protests,[81] and reflects the Commission's broader shift from mandatory compliance towards incentives-based environmental governance.

The new Farm Stewardship framework consists of three elements: Statutory Management Requirements (SMRs, i.e. existing directives and regulation, like the Nitrates and Habitats directives), Social Conditionality, and Protective Practices, the latter replacing the current Good Agricultural and Environmental Conditions (GAECs) standards. Protective Practices will be defined by Member States in their NRP Plans, instead of implementing GAECs defined at the EU level. While the existing GAECs already had quite some flexibilities, it is replaced by a more flexible framework. At the same time, Member States will need to take account of Commission national recommendations in designing the Protective Practices and consider a so-called "Do No Significant Harm" (DNSH) principle. An implication of this change is that Member States can now pay (incentivise) farmers for engaging in certain practices, whereas previously these were mandatory as a GAEC.[82]

Small farmers, moreover, are exempt from Protective Practices, and those participating in agri-environmental or climate actions can de facto be deemed compliant with the "Do No Significant Harm" (DNSH) principle. The penalty system is also simplified, giving Member States greater freedom in determining their control systems. Overall, Farm Stewardship is more general and flexible than the current conditionality system. This will allow Member States to tailor CAP interventions more towards their national needs but also risks exacerbating diverging environmental standards across Member States.[83]

80 Ministerie van Landbouw, Visserij, Voedselzekerheid en Natuur, 'Fiche 5: Voorstel nieuw gemeenschappelijk landbouwbeleid na 2027'.

81 Kaley Hart and David Baldock 'The post-2027 CAP and MFF proposals for the EU: first reflections on their environmental implications'. IEEP, 2025.

82 Alan Matthews, 'Climate and environment in the Commission's CAP proposal' CAP Reform, August 25, 2025.

83 Simone Højte and Johannes Flatz, 'Aligning the CAP with EU's climate policy', Concito, 2025.

Table 6 Actor positions on capping, degressivity & conditionality

Position	Explanation	Actors	Discourse
Strong support for redistribution and conditionality	Supports degressivity and capping as a transitional step away from hectare-based payments toward a fairer income distribution system. Advocates for maintaining and strengthening (social) conditionality, viewing it as essential to ensure a common environmental baseline and fair working conditions across Member States.	Environmental NGOs S&D	Multi-functionalist
Targeted support with flexible conditionality	Supports degressivity and capping to improve targeting of CAP support. Wants to maintain conditionality while emphasizing the need to reduce administrative burden and increase flexibility by adapting measures to national and regional conditions.	CEJA, Via Campesina Renew	Multi-functionalist, Market-based
Opposition to strong targeting, focus on simplification	Opposes or questions degressivity or capping, stressing the importance of maintaining area-based income support for all active farmers. Calls for a reassessment of conditionality, prioritizing simplification and reduced bureaucratic burden. Against expanding environmental or social conditionality.	COPA-COGEGA ECR, EPP	Productionist

Position by stakeholders and European Parliament groups

Stakeholder and EP group positions on reforming conditionalities are mixed. Some actors emphasize simplification and flexibility, while others insist that environmental and social conditionality should remain a prerequisite for all CAP funding. Among stakeholders, environmental NGOs such as EEB support the latter view, arguing that conditionality is crucial to ensure a common environmental baseline across Member States. CEJA also support maintaining conditionality but calls for less administrative burden and more flexibility to tailor measures to national and regional circumstances. In contrast, COPA-COGECA advocates for reassessing the conditionality system, calling for simplification and reduced bureaucratic burden. Via Campesina takes a neutral stance, suggesting only that CAP funding should require farmers to meet a basic set of requirements. The view of COPA-COGECA is shared with EPP, while ECR goes a step further signalling a resistance to environmental conditionality. The S&D group, by contrast, views conditionality as fundamental for achieving the CAP's objectives, advocating for its maintenance alongside stronger social conditionality and fair working conditions. Renew adopts a middle-ground position. It supports maintaining conditionality but calls for less administrative burden and more flexibility.

4.3 Agri-environmental and Climate Actions

In the Commission's post-2027 CAP proposal, Agri-Environmental and Climate Actions (AECAs) merge together the current eco-schemes (Pillar I) and environment-climate measures (Pillar II) into a single, more flexible framework aimed at providing better incentives for ecosystem services. There are two types of AECA payments available: support for voluntary management commitments (e.g. livestock extensification, agri-environmental measures or organic farm maintenance) and transition payments for farmers transitioning towards more resilient production systems (which will be set out by Member States in their NRP Plans). These transition payments have been welcomed, although notably no additional funding (or specific fund) is attached to the proposal.[84] Support for AECAs is conditional on going beyond the Statutory Management Requirements under the Farm Stewardship, as well as other relevant requirements. In the new proposal there is a possibility to move beyond cost incurred and foregone income as a basis for support to AECAs, thus offering the possibility to provide higher payments.

A large contrast to the current CAP is the removal of ring-fencing for spending on voluntary agri-environmental action. This has been substituted largely by the "climate and environment tracking". Furthermore, whereas eco-schemes receive 100% EU funding under the current CAP, the new proposal requires national co-financing of at least 30% for the merged AECA framework, extending a principle that previously only applied to Pillar II (agri-environmental) interventions.[85] While Member States are given more flexibility in their spending, for example through the new option of providing lump sum payments, these measures increase competition for the funds between AECAs and other CAP interventions.

This flexibility could cause uneven environmental outcomes.[86]

84 Alan Matthews, "Climate and environment in the Commission's CAP proposal"; Hart and Baldock, "The post-2027 CAP and MFF proposals for the EU: first reflections on their environmental implications."

85 Elsa Régnier, et al. 'European Financial Framework 2028-2034: Key issues for the agricultural sector.' Iddri, 2025.

86 Alan Matthews, 'Climate and environment in the Commission's CAP proposal'; Kaley Hart and David Baldock, "The post-2027 CAP and MFF proposals for the EU: first reflections on their environmental implications.' IEEP, 2025.

Position by stakeholders and European Parliament groups

Although stakeholder views differ regarding the level of environmental ambition and financing, their pre-proposal positions on agri-environmental and climate actions generally anticipated a more incentive-driven and flexible architecture. Among stakeholders, COPA-COGECA and CEJA both argue that environmental measures should reward farmers for delivering public goods through genuine incentives rather than simple compensation for costs incurred or income foregone, arguing for incentive-based and voluntary approaches. CEJA further supports hybrid payment systems that combine annual management commitments with results-based top-ups. In contrast, Environmental NGOs advocate for a more ambitious framework, including a ring-fenced environmental budget with regionally tailored, results-based measures and landscape-level implementation, priorities not necessarily reflected in the post-2027 proposal's removal of environmental ring-fencing. Via Campesina similarly demands substantial environmental funding for the green transition but does not specify delivery mechanisms for doing so.

EP group S&D proposed merging eco-schemes and environmental measures, which aligns with the new proposal, and suggests reserving at least 30% of the budget for environmental objectives alongside a dedicated Transition Fund. The new transition payments could be a step in that direction, although there is no dedicated funding behind it in the proposal for now. Renew calls for environmental payments focused on ensuring (long-term) food production and strategic autonomy. ECR also emphasises that environmental payments are key for sustainable developments, although they require more national tailoring. The EPP makes only limited references to agri-environmental measures. Overall, stakeholders are divided between those who favour voluntary, incentive-based approaches and those advocating for more ambitious, ring-fenced environmental measures.

Table 7 Actors positions on Agri-Environmental and Climate Actions (AECA's)

Position	Explanation	Actors	Discourse
Voluntary and incentive-based measures	Views compulsory AECA's as a limitation to productivity and competitiveness. Meeting these conditions should be better rewarded.	COPA-COGECA, ECR, EPP	Productionist
Ringfenced, strong support for AECA's	Agrees that AECA's should be better rewarded, but also more ambitious and better targeted. Funds should be (partly) redistributed from area-based of coupled income support to support for AECA's	Via Campesina, CEJA, S&D, Renew (partial redistribution) ENGOs EEB, Birdlife, WWF, Greenpeace (strong redistribution)	Multi-functionalist

4.4 Coupled Income Support (CIS)

While most direct payments are merged into degressive, area-based support, CIS remains a separate and now mandatory intervention in the CAP proposals. According to art. 11 of the new CAP regulation, Member States "shall" provide coupled support to specific sectors, products, or types of farming facing difficulties and which are important for socio-economic or environmental reasons. This support is production-linked and may target specific sectors or crops or specific types of farming. The measure is capped at a 20% allocation of the CAP income support budget, with an additional 5% permitted for protein crops, combined crop and livestock production, or farms in areas risking decline.[87]

Its scope now covers the entire agricultural sector, with some exceptions like tobacco, wine, poultry and pork. Support must be based on objective and non-discriminatory criteria, while Member States are expected to minimize the market-distorting impact of coupled support. However, despite these safeguards, CIS continues to be divisive. Hart and Baldock argue that making CIS mandatory

87 Kaley Hart and David Baldock 'The post-2027 CAP and MFF proposals for the EU: first reflections on their environmental implications', 2025; Elsa Régnier et al. 'European Financial Framework 2028-2034: Key issues for the agricultural sector'. 2025.

could divert funds from agri-environmental and climate measures, while market-oriented Member States like the Netherlands (also) oppose it for being market-distorting (see below).[88]

Position by stakeholders and European Parliament groups

Opinions on CIS vary sharply among stakeholders. Among stakeholders, COPA-COGECA strongly supports maintaining it, viewing CIS as essential for the ensuring continuity of agricultural production in vulnerable sectors (like the livestock sector in certain regions). CEJA acknowledges its necessity where other existing measures fall short but cautions against it disturbing the level playing field or leading to double support. In contrast, Environmental NGOs like the EEB advocate for complete abolition of CIS due to its negative environmental and market-distorting effects. They instead call for more targeted measures to promote sustainable farming, which are not tied to production.

Among EP groups, Renew supports maintaining CIS where it can be justified on grounds of value chain development, resilience, or food security. S&D proposes to gradually increase the share of coupled payments relative to area-based ones. The EPP and ECR have not outlined clear positions but consistently emphasize the importance of financially supporting productive sectors and farmers' incomes. Stakeholder positions on CIS thus reflect a familiar divide, with CIS being viewed as a necessary stabilizing tool on the one hand, while environmental actors view it as an outdated and harmful measure on the other.

88 Kaley Hart and David Baldock, 'The post-2027 CAP and MFF proposals for the EU: first reflections on their environmental implications'; Ministerie van LVVN, 'Fiche 5: Voorstel nieuw gemeenschappelijk landbouwbeleid na 2027', September 2025.

Table 8 Actor positions on Coupled Income Support (CIS)*

Position	Explanation	Actors	Discourse
Strong support for maintaining CIS	Views CIS as essential for continuity of production in vulnerable sectors. Sees it as a stabilizing tool for farmers' incomes.	COPA-COGEGA (likely EPP and ECR, based on emphasis on productive sectors)	Productionist
Conditional support for maintaining CIS	Supports CIS where justified (e.g. for resilience, food security or value chain development) but warns against market distortion and double support.	CEJA Renew	Multi-functionalist
Opposition to CIS	Calls for abolishing CIS due to its negative environmental impacts and market-distorting effects. Advocates for targeted measures not tied to production.	Environmental NGOs	Multi-functionalist

4.5 Risk-management

The Commission's CAP proposal places a greater emphasis on farm resilience and risk management, so farmers are better equipped to deal with shocks.[89] Member States are required to include risk management tools in their NRP Plans, unless they can demonstrate having pre-existing national schemes in place. The wording of the article leaves some ambiguity but suggest that these tools should take the form of insurances, as it refers to covering losses of income or production exceeding 20%. Payments are calculated at holding level, with some flexibility for young and new farmers and some other justified cases. The MFF proposal also introduces the Unity Safety Net to replace the Agricultural Reserve, which is the EU-level crisis fund to address major market disturbances. The new Unity Safety Net essentially performs the same function, but with a larger budget (almost doubled to 900 million annually and which, if unused in any year, will be allowed to cumulate unlike the current reserve), intended to stabilize agricultural *markets*.[90] According to Régnier et al. the proposal renationalizes

89 European Commission 'Proposal for a REGULATION OF THE EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT AND OF THE COUNCIL establishing the conditions for the implementation of the Union support to the Common Agriculture Policy for the period from 2028 to 2034', COM/2025/560 final, 2025.

90 Alan Matthews, 'Changes proposed to the management of agricultural crises'.

risk management, which could potentially stimulate Member States to improve resilience through (also) introducing more prevention measures.[91]

Position by stakeholders and European Parliament groups

The Commission's emphasis on farm resilience and proactive risk management is broadly welcomed by stakeholder, although they diverge on the instruments and governance mechanisms that should be used. COPA-COGECA supports a reinforced (ex post) risk management toolbox, including insurance schemes, mutual funds and crisis reserves, arguing that these instruments should complement national system. They further stress that the agricultural reserve must be expanded without reducing the overall CAP budget. While COPA-COGEGA supports climate adaptation measures, it does insist that it should rely on voluntary measures and incentives. CEJA similarly views risk management as a core CAP objective, calling for a stronger EU crisis reserve and management toolbox, backed up by sufficient funding. In contrast, Environmental NGOs and Via Campesina emphasize that risk management should primarily be achieved through preventive measures, such as diversification, agroecological transition, and nature-friendly farming systems.

The Renew group in Parliament also stresses adaptation and prevention but emphasizes the importance of integration with national schemes and suggests exploring an EU-level insurance mechanism. S&D proposes transforming the agricultural reserve into a multiannual, automatically replenished fund, linked to the EU's Preparedness Strategy, while ECR favours establishing a financial crisis reserve outside the CAP budget, supported by EU-backed insurance schemes. So, while producer organizations and centrist parties tend to prioritize financial and insurance-based protection, environmental groups emphasize systemic, preventive approaches based on sustainability.

91 Elsa Régnier et al. 'European Financial Framework 2028-2034: Key issues for the agricultural sector' 2025.

Table 9 Actors positions on risk management

Position	Explanation	Actors	Discourse
Financial and insurance-based resilience	Resilience (financial stability & productivity) should be achieved through a strong risk management toolbox (insurance schemes, mutual funds, crisis reserves), complemented by national systems. Emphasizes rapid crisis response, adequate funding, and voluntary climate adaptation measures.	COPA-COGEGA, CEJA, EPP, ECR, Renew, S&D	Productionist, Market-based
Environmental and systemic resilience	Rejects reliance on financial instruments as the main solution for resilience (long-term production continuity). Emphasizes preventive, systemic approaches such as agroecological transition and diversification to build resilience and reduce vulnerability to shocks.	Environmental NGOs, Via Campesina.	Multi-functionalist

4.6 Innovation

In the new CAP proposal, innovation and knowledge sharing is maintained as a key element of a thriving agricultural sector.[92] This is primarily done through the continuation and strengthening of the European Innovation Partnership for Agricultural Productivity (EIP-AGRI) and the Agricultural Knowledge and Innovation System (the AKIS). Under article 19, Member States are required to provide support for innovation and knowledge sharing but cannot use the ringfenced budget for doing so. EIP-AGRI is the main body intended to stimulate innovation through "cooperation projects" based on an "interactive innovation" model, involving at least 2 different actors. Support under this article cannot go to innovation by research bodies only, which highlights an emphasis on practice-driven innovation and collaborative knowledge development with varying stakeholders. Article 20 further obliges Member States to establish in their NRP

92 European Commission, 'Proposal for a REGULATION OF THE EUROPEAN PARLIAMENT AND OF THE COUNCIL establishing the conditions for the implementation of the Union support to the Common Agriculture Policy for the period from 2028 to 2034', 2025, p. 2.

plans knowledge and innovation sharing plans through the AKIS, which will detail how innovations will reach farmers. A key aspect of this is the provision of "farm advisory services" that help farmers implement innovations in practice. Together, these provisions aim to integrate innovation into CAP governance and improve the movement of knowledge throughout the agricultural sector.
Funding for innovation may also come from the Horizon Europe and European Competiveness Fund (ECF), which have a window for funding research in the agricultural sector. In total 40 billion euros are allocated to the policy window "Health, Biotech, Agriculture and Bioeconomy".[93] To what extent these funds will be used for agriculture is difficult to tell.

Position by stakeholders and European Parliament groups

Innovation and knowledge sharing are widely recognized as essential for a competitive and sustainable agricultural sector, and most actors support strengthening EU mechanisms such as AKIS.
Among stakeholders, COPA-COGECA emphasizes improving farmers' access to innovation and reinforcing farm advisory services alongside a more robust AKIS framework. CEJA similarly identifies innovation and knowledge sharing as essential for competitiveness, calling for advisory services for young farmers and positioning AKIS as a central part of the CAP's green architecture. By contrast, Environmental NGOs and Via Campesina make few explicit references to innovation in their position papers, suggesting that it plays less of a role in their CAP-related demands than other instruments (such as conditionality or income redistribution).
Within the European Parliament, all groups call for the promotion of innovation, knowledge transfer, and advisory services. Renew adds that farmers should be central in applied agricultural research, while the EPP argues that a stronger focus on innovation is essential to achieve environmental objectives without compromising production. For S&D and Renew innovation is not just a driver of competitiveness, but also as a tool to support the broader transition.
Overall, there is a broad consensus that the post-2027 CAP must strengthen innovation and knowledge sharing, though positions differ in reasoning, ranging from productivity and competitiveness to sustainability and accessibility for young farmers.

93 European Commission, 'Europe's Budget; Delivering innovation for EU agriculture and the agri-food sector Focus on European Competitiveness Fund and Horizon Europe', December 2025

Table 10 Actors positions on innovation

Position	Explanation	Actors	Discourse
Innovation as key driver of competitiveness and sustainability	Views innovation as essential for improving efficiency, resilience, and competitiveness, while also contributing to environmental objectives. Emphasizes technological solutions as primary means to address sustainability challenges without undermining production.	COPA-COGEGA, EPP, ECR	Productionist
Innovation as part of integrated green transition	Sees innovation as a key component of a broader approach to sustainability, resilience, and competitiveness. Emphasizes its role in supporting farmers' transition to sustainability. Supports combining innovation with other measures where appropriate.	CEJA S&D, Renew	Market-based, Multi-functionalist
Lower priority for innovation	Makes few explicit references to innovation, suggesting it may be secondary to other instruments.	Environmental NGOs, Via Campesina	

Several positions on these interventions are also reflected in the priorities of the European Parliament's Agricultural Committee for the new CAP on 7 July 2025.[94] These priorities largely overlap with the position of the largest group in the Parliament, the EPP, which hold 25% of the seats. The EP's priorities reaffirm the CAP as a distinct, well-funded policy that continues to ensure "*increased agricultural production and productivity (…) [and] supporting the stability, sustainability and competitiveness of the EU agricultural and forestry sectors*." It stresses the need for an increased, inflation-adjusted CAP budget and ring-fencing of CAP funds (particularly for area-based payments). It also firmly opposes merging the CAP into a broader "single fund" and stresses that the CAP should retain its own legal & institutional identity with a two-pillar structure. The Committee further supports improving a better and fairer targeting of this support but provides no explicit support for capping or degressivity; the effects of this should be (better) investigated. The Committee also calls for a reassessment of conditionality and emphasizes the need for greater flexibility. The Committee also want to maintain or expand coupled income support, which it views as a key tool to support vulnerable sectors. At the same time though it

94 European Parliament 'Agriculture Committee sets priorities for post-2027 CAP funding', press release, 7 July 2025.

should be conditional on maintaining a level playing field. The Committee also argues that voluntary agri-environmental and climate actions are more effective than eco-schemes and should therefore receive more money.
The Committee also "*calls on the Commission to strengthen risk management instruments in the post-2027 CAP…*" Agricultural insurance, mutual funds, agricultural reforms and income stabilization tools should be reinforced. Finally, it stresses the need to support investment in innovation, with emphasis on accessibility and knowledge exchange.

5 Possible implications for the Netherlands: targeting EU funding to targeted interventions?

In its appreciation of the Commission proposals, which was send to Dutch Parliament in September 2025, the Dutch government indicated that it plans to use the CAP to strengthen long-term food production and farmers' incomes.[95] Besides providing area-based support, this should be achieved through more targeted and specific interventions that increase innovation in the sector and involve higher payments for agri-environmental actions. This will help to meet international obligations relating to nature, water and climate. This general ambition seems supported by several national stakeholders, including farmers union LTO.[96] Many of the interventions in the proposals, which are largely seen as a continuation of the existing CAP "toolbox", are considered potentially useful for achieving this by the government.[97]

As well as considering their effectiveness, the decision to adopt specific interventions will depend on the ability to design them in an attractive way (considering e.g. height of payments, implementation cost and administrative burdens) and the funding available for different types of intervention. As different interventions can be used to meet similar objectives, and the possibilities of using different interventions are not always fully clear yet, it is difficult to make a detailed assessment of how the CAP proposals (as well as possible changes to them) themselves will affect the adoption of specific interventions at the national level. The analysis below is therefore, necessarily, an explorative one.

95 Ministerie van Buitenlandse Zaken 'Fiche 5: Voorstel nieuw gemeenschappelijk landbouwbeleid na 2027', 2025.

96 LTO 'Vergroening landbouw in de knel in EU-begrotingsonderhandelingen' 15 September 2025.

97 Ministerie van Buitenlandse Zaken 'Fiche 5: Voorstel nieuw gemeenschappelijk landbouwbeleid na 2027', 2025.

As discussed, the EU budget allocated for agriculture in the next MFF will decrease. For the Netherlands, the ring-fenced CAP budget will decrease from 5.6 billion in the current period to 5.1 billion in the 2028–2034 period, a reduction of around 9%. While Member States can decide to increase the budget, the unearmarked fund in the NRP Fund provides little additional financial leeway as it is a small budget for the Netherlands, with 2 billion euros. To 'top up' the agricultural budget to the current level of funding, the Netherlands would have to use up to 36% of this budget, according to Matthews.[98] It is expected to be difficult to make this fund available for the agricultural sector, given the other priorities in the NRP Plan (including Cohesion policy), although some synergies, as envisaged by the Commission, are perceived to be possible.
In response to calls from European farmer organisations, the European Parliament as well as various national agricultural ministries, the Commission has very recently (January 2026) suggested to make changes in the proposed NRP budget's allocation. This change would enable spending NRP funds that are reserved for unforeseen developments (the so-called flexibility fund) already at the beginning of the programming period and spend these on agriculture. According to think tank Farm Europe this could increase the budget with €45 billion, if Member States decide to use this money and do so solely for the CAP.[99] Alan Matthews shows that this would lead to a significant increase in several Member States; for the Netherlands, however, this would lead to an increase of 5% of the minimum (ringfenced) budget.[100]

Given the substantially smaller EU budget for agricultural spending that will be available the next period, it is recognised by most national stakeholders that clear choices must be made regarding which interventions to adopt. According to the Dutch government, at least 40% of the ring-fenced budget for the CAP would have to be spent on area-based support in the Netherlands under the current proposals, based on the minimum national average spending of €130 per hectare and the original proposed budget.[101] Another percentage of the

98 Alan Mathhews, 'Further reflections on CAP governance and budget – CAP Reform'

99 The money can also be used for funding dedicated to rural areas.

100 Alan Matthews 'Potential increase in CAP funding in next MFF', 7 January 2026. This suggestion was made by the Commission to appease concerns about the consequence of the Mercosur agreement. See also Farm Europe, 'President von der Leyen recognises that at least €400 billion are needed for the CAP', 7 January 2026.

101 Ministerie van Buitenlandse Zaken 'Fiche 5: Voorstel nieuw gemeenschappelijk landbouwbeleid na 2027', 2025.

remaining fund would further have to be spent on coupled incomes support (CIS), up to a maximum of 25% of the total spending. While the proposal introduced an obligation to adopt CIS, a minimum spending is not specified in the proposals. For both support schemes 100% EU funding must be used. Together these two interventions can thus take a large share of the ringfenced budget. Most other interventions financed with the remaining ringfenced fund, as mentioned, must be co-financed at 30% (see also table 4).
While a total national financing (100%) could also be an option to adopt CAP interventions, it must be seen if this is desirable. There appears to be support among national stakeholders that national or regional support schemes should remain in place besides CAP interventions. These domestic schemes will likely compete with additional funding for CAP interventions.

In its response to the proposals, the Dutch government made clear that it opposes the minimum spending requirement for area-based payments.[102]
In addition, it has also called for greater flexibility and removal of obligations to adopt specific interventions such as coupled income support (CIS). Other stakeholders, however, perceive some opportunities for using CIS, provided this does not lead to market distortion.
Lowering the minimum spending on area-based payments would free up more EU finances for targeted interventions, like support for disadvantages resulting from national mandatory requirements or support for agri-environmental measures. Additional EU financing would also be welcome to pay for agri-environmental measures and provide higher payments to farmers to adopt certain measures. This is in line with government policy, although the basis for these higher payments (and their financial implication) must be clarified.
Although the new AECA requires 30% co-financing, the Dutch government has expressed a positive attitude towards integrating eco-schemes and agri-environmental measures, as this would enable different measures to be implemented and "stacked" more effectively.

As indicated, concerns have been expressed at the EU level that Member States will limit the adoption of interventions that require co-financing. There is a perceived risk that Member States may decide to use a large amount of the earmarked funds for area-based or coupled payments, which could

102 Ministerie van Buitenlandse Zaken 'Fiche 2: [MFK] Oprichting Europees Fonds Nationale en Regionale Partnerschap plannen' 2025.

limit the adoption of interventions that help meet environmental obligations. There have therefore been calls at the EU level to maintain ring-fencing for agri-environmental measures, as is the case with the current CAP. So far, the Commission and the Member States seem reluctant to introduce this, however, as it could lead to demands for further ringfencing by specific stakeholders and sectors. This would also reduce the flexibility provided by the CAP proposals.
Discussions on ring-fencing agri-environmental measures may resurface, however, when the proposed capping and degressivity rules for area-based support are opened for reconsideration during negotiations. Attempts to introduce capping and degressivity of area-based support during earlier reforms of the CAP did not survive the trilogue negotiations, and there is no clear support for the Commission's proposal on this yet in the Council of Ministers. Given the limited farm size in the Netherlands, the consequences of a removal of capping and degressivity would be limited. This could, however, lead to a greater spending on area-based support as compared to agri-environmental measures in other Member States, which would undermine the commonality of the CAP and its contribution to environmental objectives.

There have been suggestions to also use the direct area-based payments to support farmers (with 100% EU funding) for more sustainable practices under the proposals. The area-based payment scheme, as discussed, allows for a regional differentiation in area-based payments considering natural and specific constraints to farming. What specific constraints could fall under this criterium, and if these can also include certain "legal constraints" is not fully clear.
It seems not possible to pay for legal constraints under EU legislation. If national legislation demands higher standards, however, farmers can be compensated. In addition to question about the legal possibilities to do this, the question is also to what extent such a differentiation would be in line with the shift from "obligations to incentives" under the new CAP proposals. More practical difficulties (and administrative burdens) could also be foreseen in implementing this differentiation in area-based payments. Currently, the uniform area-based payments are relatively easy to implement, which also makes them an attractive intervention for governments.

In the proposals there is an obligation to adopt interventions to support innovation through EIP-AGRI and AKIS. Given the importance that is attributed to innovation by the government this intervention is welcomed in the governments'

appreciation of the proposal. In the current proposal, however, support for this does not come from ringfenced budget for the CAP. Funding for this intervention should therefore come from the unringfenced part of the NRP fund and co-financing or financed with national money. It is recognised that this could set limits to the use of this intervention, especially when there will be a possible additional demand to do this based on the unearmarked fund, as suggested by the Commission.[103] In light of these constraints, Horizon Europe and the European Competiveness Fund could be turned to attract additional funding for innovation. In its appreciation of the funds the Dutch government recognises the potential of these funds to contribute to competitiveness, sustainability and resilience of the agricultural sector, but also stresses that this support should be complementary to the support coming from the NRP Fund.[104]

In relation to risk management, the Dutch government finally, indicates that (weather) insurances, as required by the Commission, could play a role but should be part of a mix of different interventions to deal with risks. It indicates that it is important to focus especially on preventive measures to increase the resilience of farmers, a position that finds support with farmer union LTO.[105] Rather than spending CAP funding for risk management on risk insurance schemes, funding should be directed to farmers to adapt to changing climate and weather conditions, according to the Dutch government.[106]

103 This could be an implication of the "rural target" that has been proposed, although this is not fully clear at the time of writing.

104 Ministerie van Buitenlandse Zaken, ; Fiche 11: [MFK] Europees Concurrentievermogenfonds' and 'Fiche 12: Voorstel Verordening en Besluit Horizon Europa– het Europese kaderprogramma voor onderzoek en innovatie voor de periode 2028–2034'

105 LTO 'EU-begrotingsvoorstellen: kleinere landbouwbegroting, groter ongelijk speelveld voor boeren' 2025.

106 Ministerie van LVVN, 'Fiche 5: Voorstel nieuw gemeenschappelijk landbouwbeleid na 2027', September 2025.

6 Conclusion

The most recent vision of the Commission on the CAP clearly reflects a more productionist discourse. Whereas the Farm to Fork Strategy of the Commission had a clear focus on sustainability, the focus has shifted (back) towards food security and enhancing the competitiveness of European agriculture with the help of strong government support.[107] Geo-political and economic developments are interpreted through a productionist and neo-mercantilist lens in which the continuation of existing farming practices (and support for farmers) and productivity is considered crucial and linked to overall strategic autonomy of the EU. This view is shared by different stakeholders, notably COPA-COGEGA and EP groups, including EPP and ECR.

This shift is also reflected (though not always made that explicit) in the policy proposal for a new CAP, in which sustainability is one among several objectives with which it must be balanced. At the level of the interventions, this change in discourse is reflected for example in changes in the conditionalities attached to area-based support, the increase of the maximum support for coupled income support and the absence of a ringfencing for agri-environmental spending by Member States. These changes make it possible to continue granting support for existing farming practices by providing more room for Member States to decide on how to balance the objectives of food security, farm income, competitiveness and sustainability.

At the national level there appears to be is sufficient leeway to align the proposals (at least rhetorically) with a more multi-functionalist discourse.[108] Adopting interventions in line with this discourse is somewhat hampered, however, by several requirements in the proposals, like the obligation to provide a minimum level of area-based income support, which limits the possibilities to spend EU funding on other interventions. The proposal of the Commission still allows Member States to adopt interventions that target support to more specific activities and results, but this will require national co-financing. This analysis

107 IEEP, From Sustainability to Competitiveness: what shifting narratives means for EU agricultural policy

108 Cf. Gerry Alons and Pieter Zwaan 'New wine in different bottles: negotiating and selling the CAP post-2013 reform' Sociologia Ruralis 56.3, 2016.

also shows that a market-based discourse is put forward by the government as a counter-discourse to object the use of different interventions that are required under the CAP proposal and are believed to lead to market distortion or competitive disadvantages for Dutch farmers.

Changes in the proposed legislation will be needed to address this tension. An increase in flexibility to not make use of certain interventions – by simply removing an obligation – will often suffice for doing so. It is difficult to tell to what extent greater flexibility will be acceptable to the Commission, the European Parliament and other Member States (which we have not included in our analysis). Likely this would be interpreted to (further) undermine the commonality of EU agricultural policy and distort the "level playing field" between Member States. As the latter will eventually weigh in on the choices that Member States make in adopting certain interventions, the question of how to maintain a level playing field is likely to become a key issue in the negotiation on the CAP at the EU and the national level.

Annex I Analysed documents of Parliamentary groups and stakeholders

Parliamentary groups

ECR 'Strong, Sovereign, Competitive; The ECR Vision For The Future Of European Agriculture', 2025.
EPP 'Position Paper on A European Farmers' Deal - The EPP vision for Agriculture in Europe', 2024.
Greens/EFA 'Six steps to sustainable farming', 2025.
Socialist and Democrats 'Position Paper on the post-2027 Common Agricultural Policy and the Future of Agriculture and Food', 2025.
Renew 'The future of agriculture', position paper, 2025.

Stakeholders

Birdlife et al. 'Time for farmers and nature to thrive; A proposal for a performance-based policy to drive the transition of Europe's food and farming sector', 2025.
COPA-COGEGA 'COPA and COGECA Vision for the future of EU Agriculture' 18 December 2024.
CEJA 'A Common Agricultural Policy post-2027 for generational renewal' , Position paper, May 2025.
European Coordination Via Campesina (2025) 'Post-2027 CAP: Building Food Sovereignty Fair prices, more farmers and a transition to social, sustainable and agroecological agri-food systems', 2025.
FoodDrinkEurope 'FoodDrinkEurope preliminary input to the EU Vision for Agriculture and Food', 2025.